

# **BAIS: International Relations**

**Power, Institutions, and Ideas: Traditional IR Theories**

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## In-Class Survey

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Scan the QR code or follow the link below.



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# Recent Geopolitical Developments

Three stories – three different ways of seeing the world

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## 1. Trump threatens tariffs over Greenland

- Coercive diplomacy? Power politics? Or an institutional crisis?

## 2. Western leaders visit Beijing amid U.S. uncertainty

- Balancing behavior? Economic interdependence? An identity shift?

## 3. NATO sets 5% GDP defense benchmark as U.S. deprioritizes Europe

- Alliance burden-sharing? Institutional adaptation? Evolving security identities?

### Today's goal

By the end of this lecture, you will be able to explain each of these events through the lens of realism, liberalism, and constructivism.

# Roadmap

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## Before the break

1. Major IR theories
  - Realism
  - Liberalism
  - Constructivism

## After the break

2. Survey review
3. Applying theory: case studies
4. Reflection

## Note

A supplementary bibliography for all scholars referenced in this lecture is available on Brightspace.

# Realism

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## Realism: Core Assumptions

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- **Power and self-interest:** Global politics is fundamentally about power struggles
- **Human nature and anarchy:**
  - People are inherently selfish and competitive (egoism)
  - The international system operates in *anarchy* – no higher authority above states
  - States prioritize survival and security (self-help)
- **Power politics (*Realpolitik*):** States act primarily in pursuit of power
- Not all realists or realist theories are the same

## Realism: Core Variants

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### Classical realism

- Power politics rooted in a pessimistic view of **human nature**
- Human egoism becomes *state egoism*: “the social world is but a projection of human nature onto the collective plane” (Morgenthau, 1962)
- Conflict is therefore an enduring tendency of international politics

### Neorealism (structural realism)

- State behavior is shaped by the **structure** of the international system
- Anarchy, not human nature, is the key source of competition and conflict
- Different variants disagree on how states respond to structural pressures

## Neorealism: Offensive Realism

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- Anarchy and uncertainty about intentions incentivize states to seek power
- **Great powers** aim to **maximize relative power**
- **Regional hegemony** is the highest feasible goal for great powers
- Non-great powers face strong constraints and often:
  - bandwagon with dominant powers
  - pursue limited, opportunistic gains

### Example

The rise of China as a challenge to U.S. primacy in East Asia



## Neorealism: Defensive Realism

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- States are **security maximizers**, not power maximizers
- Excessive power accumulation increases threat perceptions
- Overexpansion provokes counter-balancing and reduces security
- States therefore favor **balancing** strategies:
  - internal balancing (building capabilities)
  - external balancing (alliances)
  - restraint to avoid provoking counter-balancing

### Example

States accommodating U.S. power after the Cold War

## Neoclassical Realism

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International structure (anarchy) matters, but state behavior is also shaped by **domestic factors**:

- State capacity
- Domestic politics and ideology
- Leadership perceptions and decision-making

The pressures of structural features are conditioned by domestic factors. Sub-national factors shape the choices states actually make.

### Example

Nazi Germany pursued expansion not solely due to systemic pressures, but because of domestic ideology and leadership ambitions.

## Realism: Summary

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| Variation            | Key Features                                                                                | Major Thinkers                                                                             |
|----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Classical Realism    | Power politics driven by human nature (egoism, fear, ambition).                             | E.H. Carr, Hans Morgenthau                                                                 |
| Defensive Realism    | States seek security, favoring balancing and restraint; overexpansion is counterproductive. | Kenneth Waltz, Stephen Walt                                                                |
| Offensive Realism    | States maximize relative power under anarchy; great powers seek regional hegemony.          | John Mearsheimer                                                                           |
| Neoclassical Realism | Domestic factors and leader perceptions mediate how states respond to systemic pressures.   | Gideon Rose, Randall Schweller, Fareed Zakaria, Keren Yarhi-Milo, Jennifer Sterling-Folker |

# Liberalism

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## Liberalism: Core Assumptions

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- **Reason and cooperation:** States are capable of rational cooperation under anarchy
- **Conflict is not inevitable:** War is possible, but not unavoidable
- **Institutions and norms matter:** Rules, law, and organizations shape expectations and behavior
- **Domestic politics matter:** Regime type and societal preferences influence foreign policy
- **Progress is possible:** International politics can become more cooperative over time

### Key contrast with realism

Liberals argue that realists underestimate how institutions, interdependence, and domestic politics interact with anarchy.

## Liberalism: Major Variants

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### **Interdependence liberalism**

- Economic exchange creates mutual dependence among states
- Interdependence raises the costs of conflict and disruption

### **Republican (democratic) liberalism**

- Domestic political institutions constrain leaders
- Democracies resolve disputes peacefully with one another

### **Neoliberal institutionalism**

- Institutions facilitate cooperation under anarchy
- They reduce uncertainty, information problems, and transaction costs

# The Liberal International Order (LIO)

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## What it is

- A theory of international order, not a separate variant of liberalism
- Explains how power and institutions combine to sustain order
- Developed to explain the post-1945 U.S.-led system

## How it builds on liberalism

- From neoliberal institutionalism: rules and institutions stabilize cooperation
- From republican liberalism: liberal states are more rule-bound and legitimate
- From interdependence liberalism: open markets raise exit and conflict costs

## What it adds

- Explains why leading states accept rules and constraints
- Order depends on legitimacy and restraint, not force alone

## Liberalism: Summary

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| Variation                   | Key Features                                                                          | Major Thinkers                                  |
|-----------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| Interdependence Liberalism  | Economic ties and globalization raise the costs of conflict.                          | David Ricardo, Richard Cobden, John Bright      |
| Republican Liberalism       | Democratic institutions promote peaceful relations among democracies.                 | Immanuel Kant, Michael Doyle                    |
| Neoliberal Institutionalism | Institutions enable cooperation by reducing uncertainty and promoting absolute gains. | Robert Keohane, Joseph Nye                      |
| Liberal International Order | Rule-based order sustained by institutions, legitimacy, and hegemonic self-restraint. | John Ikenberry, Daniel Deudney, Rebecca Lissner |



# Constructivism

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## Constructivism: Core Assumptions

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- **Social construction of reality:** States act not on material power alone but on shared ideas and identities
- **Identity matters:** State interests are shaped by historical, social, and political contexts
- **Norms and ideas shape behavior:** Social norms and discourse shape world politics – not just material capabilities
- **Anarchy is not fixed:** The international system is shaped by how states interact and interpret their relationships

### Key contrast with realism and liberalism

Both realists and liberals take state interests as given. Constructivists ask: *where do those interests come from?*

## Wendt (1992): “Anarchy Is What States Make of It”

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Challenges realism and liberalism: anarchy does not inherently lead to conflict or cooperation – it depends on how states interact.

### Three cultures of anarchy:

1. **Hobbesian** (Conflictual) – States as existential threats
  - e.g., early 20th-century Europe
2. **Lockean** (Competitive) – States as rivals who recognize sovereignty
  - e.g., the Cold War (1947–1991)
3. **Kantian** (Cooperative) – States as partners with shared norms
  - e.g., the EU and NATO

Which culture characterizes U.S.-China relations today? U.S.-Europe?

## Constructivism: Summary

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| Concept             | Key Features                                                                                           | Major Thinkers                    |
|---------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|
| Social Construction | State interests and identities are shaped by social interaction, not given by nature or structure.     | Alexander Wendt, Nicholas Onuf    |
| Norms & Ideas       | Shared norms, discourse, and ideas shape state behavior as much as material power.                     | Martha Finnemore, Kathryn Sikkink |
| Cultures of Anarchy | Anarchy can produce conflict, competition, or cooperation depending on how states perceive each other. | Alexander Wendt                   |

## The Trio: Realism vs. Liberalism vs. Constructivism

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|                     | <b>Realism</b>                  | <b>Liberalism</b>         | <b>Constructivism</b> |
|---------------------|---------------------------------|---------------------------|-----------------------|
| Philosophical Roots | Thucydides, Machiavelli, Hobbes | Locke, Kant, Smith        | –                     |
| View of Anarchy     | Inherent; leads to conflict     | Mitigated by institutions | Socially constructed  |
| State Interests     | Fixed: power & security         | Fixed: cooperation        | Shaped by identity    |
| Key Actors          | States                          | States + institutions     | States + norms        |
| Epistemology        | Positivist                      | Positivist                | Post-positivist       |

# Break

We will resume in 10 minutes.

## Survey Results

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Let's see how you did – and what the experiment revealed.

### **Three things to discuss:**

1. Knowledge check: How well did you do the readings?
2. The framing experiment: Did the analyst brief you read shape your perceptions?
3. What does this tell us about how discourse and framing work in IR?

# Applying the Theories

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# Mearsheimer (2019): “Bound to Fail”

## The rise and fall of the liberal international order

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After the Cold War, the U.S. built a **liberal international order** (LIO) premised on spreading democracy, open markets, and strong institutions. Why does a leading realist think this was doomed from the start?

### The argument

- The LIO required *liberal hegemony* – U.S. dominance to enforce liberal norms
- It provoked nationalist backlash and great-power resistance
- It led to costly interventions (Iraq, Libya)

### The implication

- The LIO was a product of unipolarity that could not survive the return of great-power competition
- This is a **realist critique of liberalism**

# Responding to Mearsheimer

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## Liberal response

- Institutions are resilient – they have adapted before and can again
- Economic interdependence creates strong incentives against conflict
- The LIO's problems were about implementation, not inherent flaws

## Constructivist response

- The “failure” narrative is itself a product of realist framing
- Norms of human rights, sovereignty, and multilateralism are deeply embedded
- Whether the order “fails” depends on how states choose to act

## Connection to Wendt

If anarchy is what states make of it, then the collapse of the liberal order is not inevitable – it is a choice shaped by discourse and identity.

# Ukraine-Russia: Theories in Practice

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## Realist lens

- *Security dilemma*: Russia perceives NATO expansion as an intolerable threat
- Ukraine as a strategic buffer zone
- Western miscalculation about Russian red lines

## Constructivist lens

- Russia's actions shaped by identity – imperial narrative, great-power self-image
- Framing of Ukraine as historically “Russian”
- Western engagement rooted in norms of sovereignty and self-determination

**Liberal lens:** Failure of institutions (UN veto), but also evidence that economic sanctions can impose real costs – interdependence as leverage.

## IR Theories Applied: Summary

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| Theory         | What it explains well                                             | What it struggles with                                             |
|----------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Realism        | Power competition, security dilemmas, alliance formation          | Cooperation, norm change, why democracies rarely fight each other  |
| Liberalism     | Institutional cooperation, trade peace, democratic peace          | Why institutions sometimes fail, why liberal orders collapse       |
| Constructivism | Identity politics, norm diffusion, how perceptions shape conflict | Predicting specific outcomes, material constraints on state action |

# Wrapping Up

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## Questions to Consider

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Think about these before next week:

1. How do different IR theories explain the same events differently, like nuclear proliferation? What does each highlight, and what does it overlook?
2. Can realism, liberalism, and constructivism be combined, or are they fundamentally incompatible?

## Next Week: Security Dilemmas & Nuclear Proliferation

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### Required readings (Week 3):

- Heywood & Whitham, *Global Politics*, Ch. 12: “Nuclear Proliferation and Disarmament”
- Sagan, S. (1996). “Why Do States Build Nuclear Weapons? Three Models in Search of a Bomb.” *International Security*, 21(3), 54–86.

Recommended readings listed on Brightspace.

Thank you!

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